

Lam Son 719

On February 8, 1971, the ARVN sent a task force of 15,000 troops into Laos with heavy US air and artillery support. Their goal was to disrupt and block off the Ho Chi Minh Trail. Codenamed Lam Son 719, the operation was a major test of Vietnamization.

◀◀ BEFORE

By 1971, the Ho Chi Minh Trail had been operational for 16 years, bringing soldiers and supplies from North Vietnam through Laos and Cambodia into South Vietnam.

SUPPLY ROUTE

Despite steady [air bombardment](#) during the 1960s, and the [Cambodian incursion](#) in 1970, men and materiel continued to flow south. During 1970, an estimated 8,000 men and 10,000 tons of supplies moved along the trail each month.

FORBIDDEN ZONE

After the Cambodian incursion, Congress repeatedly attempted to limit the US president's war powers and block any expansion of the war beyond Vietnam. The **Cooper-Church amendment** to a military appropriation bill finally passed Congress in December 1970. It clearly **prohibited** the use of US ground forces in Laos.

In early 1971, General Creighton Abrams planned an operation to interdict the flow of North Vietnamese (NVA) and supplies into South Vietnam along the Ho Chi Minh Trail. The initiative was welcomed by both the US and South Vietnamese administrations.

Both President Nixon and President Thieu were eager to see the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) succeed as US troop strength declined, to show that the ARVN was capable of holding its own in battle.

Because of the Cooper-Church Amendment, US ground forces could not enter Laos, through which much of the Ho Chi Minh Trail passed. Therefore, it was decided that the operation would be an ARVN ground attack with American air, long-range artillery, transportation, and intelligence support. There were no American advisers or forward air controllers with the ARVN units.